kind. Lhamo later said, “My first teacher of compassion was my mother.” *Compassion* means wanting to help someone who is suffering, hurt, or in trouble. Lhamo saw compassion in the way his mother treated him and the way she shared what she could with the needy people in their village.

One of Lhamo’s favorite games was to pack up his clothes and pretend to go on trips. He straddled the windowsill, pretending to ride a horse. His mother asked him where he was going. He said he was headed to Lhasa, the capital city of Tibet.



Lhamo didn’t know that more than a thousand miles away, in Lhasa, something important was happening. In December 1933, the Thirteenth Dalai Lama had died. So Tibet had been without a leader for two years. Government officials and religious leaders had started the search to find the next Dalai Lama.

What Is a Dalai Lama?

Tibetan Buddhism is divided into groups. The most powerful one is called the *Gelugpa*, or Yellow Hat school. The most important person in this school is called the Dalai Lama. (*Dalai* is from the word for “ocean,” and *lama* means “teacher.”) He is considered the political and religious leader of Tibet.